

Football

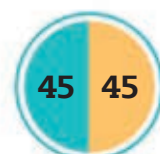
Football is one of the most popular sports in the world. Its appeal is its simplicity: all you need to play is a ball, and then you can play virtually anywhere – on grass, indoors, in the street, or even on the beach.

THE GAME

During a football match, two teams of 11 players try to kick a ball into each other's goal. The aim is to score more goals than the other team. If no one scores any goals, or the scores are equal at the end of the game, it is called a draw.



LASTS
90 MINUTES



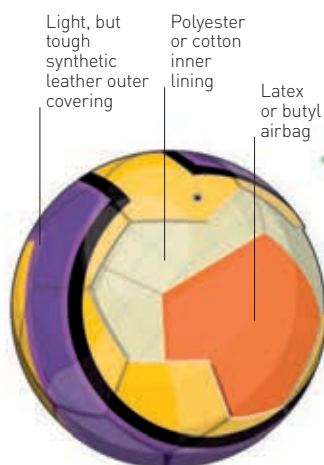
TWO HALVES OF
45 MINUTES



HAS TWO TEAMS
OF 11 PLAYERS

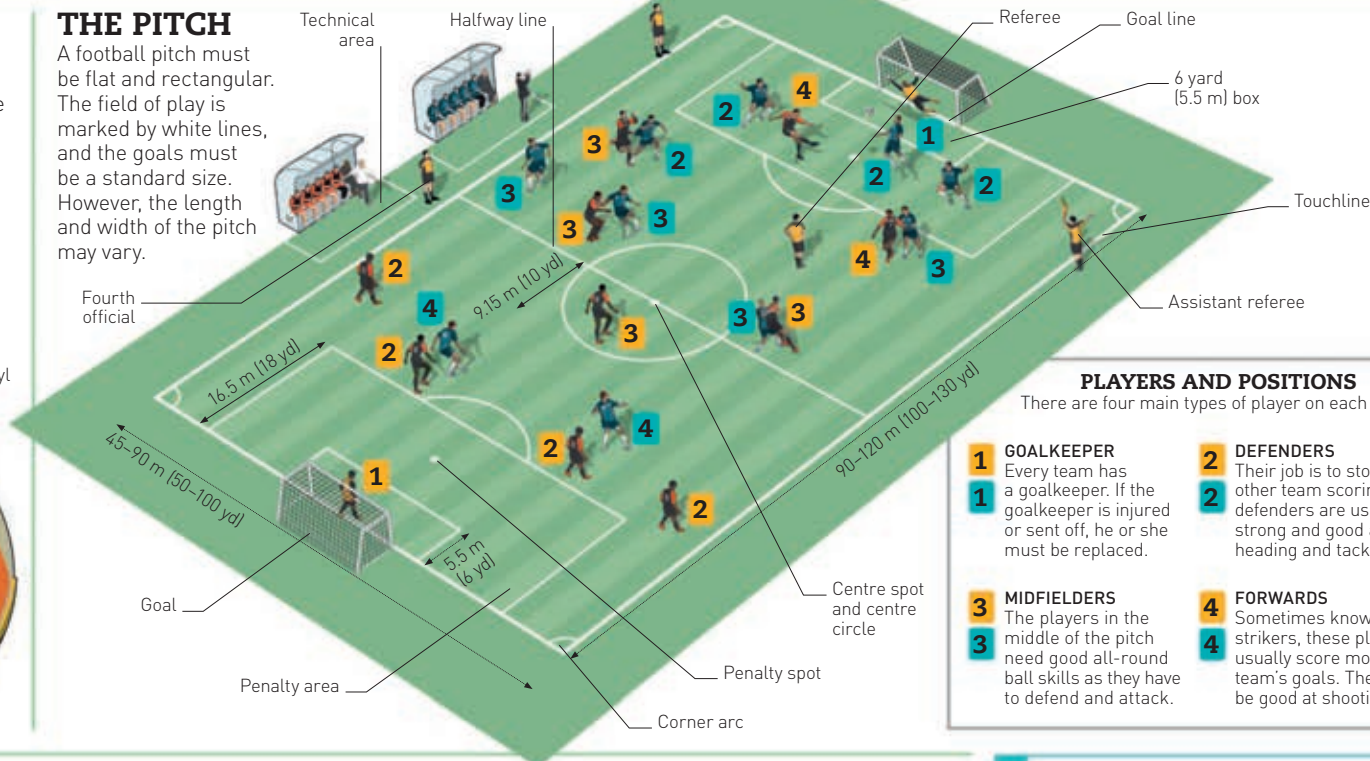
THE BALL

The first footballs were made of inflated pigs' bladders covered with leather. They were heavy and not very bouncy, especially if they got wet. Modern footballs are made of high-tech materials and are much lighter and bouncier.



THE PITCH

A football pitch must be flat and rectangular. The field of play is marked by white lines, and the goals must be a standard size. However, the length and width of the pitch may vary.



PLAYERS AND POSITIONS

There are four main types of player on each team.

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| 1 GOALKEEPER
Every team has a goalkeeper. If the goalkeeper is injured or sent off, he or she must be replaced. | 2 DEFENDERS
Their job is to stop the other team scoring, so defenders are usually strong and good at heading and tackling. |
| 3 MIDFIELDERS
The players in the middle of the pitch need good all-round ball skills as they have to defend and attack. | 4 FORWARDS
Sometimes known as strikers, these players usually score most of the team's goals. They must be good at shooting. |

FORMATIONS

Before a match, the manager organizes the players in a way that he or she thinks will help them to win. This is known as the formation. The formation is usually a set of three or four numbers, which show how many defenders, midfielders, and forwards there are. Often teams will start a match in one formation and then change during the game.



4-4-2
In this basic formation there are four defenders, four midfielders, and two forwards. The two central midfielders have different roles – one defensive and one attacking.



3-5-2
This is an attacking formation. The two wide midfielders, often known as wing backs, have to help out in both defence and attack.



4-5-1
This is a defensive formation. There is only one striker, who receives support from the wide midfield players.

GOALKEEPER
Every team must have a goalkeeper, so he or she is not included in the formation.

RULES OF FOOTBALL

During a match, a referee, assisted by officials on each touchline, makes sure the game is played fairly. Football has 17 official rules, or laws. Here are the three most fundamental rules, which apply whether you are playing in the park with friends, or in the World Cup.

- NO HANDS**
A goalkeeper is allowed to touch the ball with his or her hands during a match, but only in the penalty area. If another player touches the ball with his or her hand, the opposition wins a free kick. If a defender touches the ball with his or her hand in the penalty area, it is a penalty.
- FOUL PLAY**
If a player commits a foul, such as a bad tackle or a handball, a free kick (or penalty if it is inside the penalty area) is awarded to the opposition. For a bad foul or a deliberate handball, a player is shown a yellow card. If that player then commits a second yellow-card offence, he or she will be shown a red card and "sent off" from the pitch. For serious foul play, a player can be shown a straight red card.
- OFFSIDE**
The purpose of the offside rule is to make it harder for a side to score goals. Attackers cannot just stand by the goal waiting to score – there must be at least two defenders between them and the goal line when the ball is passed to them. One of these defenders is usually the goalkeeper. If a player is ruled offside, the defending team is awarded a free kick.

FIFA WORLD CUP

The Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) governs football around the world. Since 1932 FIFA has organized an international competition to find the best football team in the world. It is called the FIFA World Cup and the finals tournament is held every four years. So far, only eight different countries have ever won it.



AROUND THE WORLD

FIFA has 208 members, but each continent, apart from Antarctica, also has its own football federation. These govern the game in the region and organize international competitions at club and country level.

UEFA (EUROPE) AND CAF (AFRICA) ARE THE LARGEST FEDERATIONS, EACH WITH 52 MEMBERS